

± 0]

49. 1745 – XV, apr (2 = 1, 1/2 = 11, 1 = 85 [3 subs], odd = 1) = 98; [$f^{35} \pm 0$]

50. 1746 – XIV, apr (2 = 1, 1/2 = 11, 1 = 85 [3 subs], odd = 1) = 98; [$f^{35} \pm 0$]

51. 1652 – XVI, eap (2 = 1, 1/2 = 3, 1 = 21) = 25; [f^{35} frag]

52. 1742 – XIII, ap (2 = 1, 1/2 = 11, 1 = 85 [3 subs]) = 97; [$f^{35} \pm 5$]

Again, setting aside the f^{35} MSS for the moment, absolutely no two MSS are identical. The rest of the Byzantine MSS are all distinct, some really so, yet all clearly fall within the Byzantine tradition. These 30 MSS represent as many exemplars; there was no ‘inbreeding’, no stuffing the ballot box; each copyist tried to reproduce what was in front of him, regardless of the quality of text. Since the MSS were still there in 1800, they were not made to fill an order from elsewhere.

Also, where did the monasteries get the parchment for their ongoing production of MSS? Did they have money to go out and buy from tanneries? It seems to me more probable that they made their own from the skins of the sheep and goats that they ate. In such an event it could easily take several years to get enough for a single New Testament. The problem of finding enough parchment mitigates against the mass production of copies at any time in the vellum era. Three of the dated MSS at Sinai are eight years apart (1308, 1316, 1324)—might it have taken that long to gather enough vellum?

Now let’s consider the f^{35} group. Seven are $f^{35} \pm 2$, but no two of them have an identical profile—I have put the deviant variants within () at the end of the line, so the reader can check that at a glance. Five are $f^{35} \pm 1$, but no two of them have an identical profile either, as the reader can see at a glance. So these twelve MSS must also have been copied from as many exemplars—we now have 44 MSS that were copied from distinct exemplars. Ah, but there are eight MSS with a perfect f^{35} profile; what of them? Well, let’s start with the contents: three contain **eapr**, three contain **eap**, two contain **apr**—at the very least, these three groups must represent distinct exemplars. So now we are down to a maximum of five MSS that might not represent a distinct exemplar. Setting aside preconceived ideas, what objective basis could anyone have for affirming that these five were not copied on the same principle as the rest, namely to preserve the text of